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Synaesthesia and the Affect of Programming in SuperCollider

: : Forming a relationship with code in order to realise the body as an immersive environment : :

Abstract

> *[Humans] and things exchange properties and replace one another; this is what gives technological projects their full savour.*
> (Latour, 2004:34)

Whilst essentially unique, all systems of language share the ability to express connections, relationship between things constituting the driving force behind the evolution of ideas and as a result of this, existence in the physical. At present it is the language of computational technology that is most often utilised by sound and multimedia artists as a means to creatively realise concrete representations of subterranean sensory experiences. An example of this is the collaborative digital music adventures that take place in real time and remotely utilising the Open SoundControl (OSC) Protocol (Wright, 2006). Such an activity exists potentially to redefine current attitudes surrounding the inter-connection and interdependency of life.

The ability to creatively map scientific data and subjective detail in previously unimagined ways, to output high-level ideas based in a combination of the 'emotional and perceptible structural level'(Lockwood, 2003) has contributed to a deepening of thought regarding the relationship between the human being and their environment. Furthermore, it has given rise to a context wherein the brain and body (computational systems in their own right) and hence pleasure and affective learning no longer reside abstracted from one another. This is where my interest lies.

I am a student with a limited amount of preconceptions surrounding the abilities of programming given that I have not long been acquainted with digital music technology and compositional practices involving the use of computer code. It is most likely due to the premature nature of these relationships that I intuit computational technology's langue (its system of communication) as the most relevant means for explorative and interpretive analysis of the natural unfolding of daily habitual practices, i.e. activity and its movement, an event and its structure, within modern society. Henceforth, influenced by generative research methods, I have chosen to "immerse" myself into the art of object-oriented audio synthesis programming in order that I may realise and in turn musically "codify" an artistic expression of that which currently exists on the periphery of the neurologists' quantifiable logic: the synaesthetic experience during [and the affect of] the practice of coding.

James McCartney, author of the seminal object-oriented audio-synthesis programming language SuperCollider, regards 'synthesis' as a complex problem demanding a language that is highly expressive in order to deal with such complexity. (McCartney, 1999) I in turn perceive the text-based lexicon of McCartney's SuperCollider and the affect of programming in the object-oriented style as offering me a viable and effective means through which to undertake my research and explore the underlying hypothesis that initially inspired my university Honours project: the body as an immersive environment.

Within a many-layered, multi-dimensional present resides the antidote to the infancy of [our] immediate thoughts; the potential for a collective and/or individual experience that transcends traditional representations of thought, the lexical, the narrative of 'expectation denied and expectation fulfilled.'(Lockwood, 2004) Delving into this place
- - via code, I anticipate the physical act of programming as a way to quantify the senses and, during my future research I expect it to be an original line of enquiry into the feminine experience. At present I aim to realise the creation of a synaesthetic work indicative of the affect of programming.

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